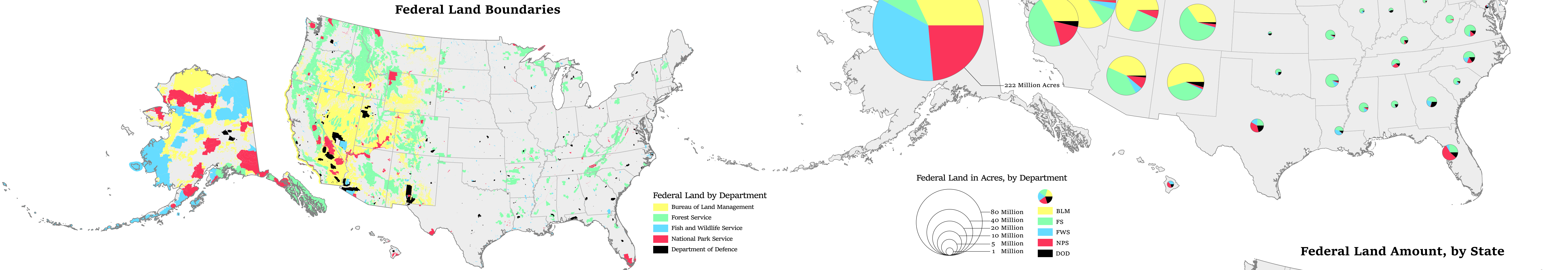


# Federal Land in the US

Nearly a third of the American soil is managed by the federal government. The vast majority of that land is managed by five departments: the Bureau of Land Management, the Forest Service, the Fish and Wildlife Service, the National Park Service, and the Department of Defense.

How can the geography and history of the US tell us about where these lands are located? What can their location tell us about each states' geography? These maps will explore the spatial patterns of federal land in the United States.



The federal government’s land management is carried out by agencies with unique missions and histories, reflecting the diverse ways these lands are used and protected. The Bureau of Land Management (BLM), the largest of the five, focuses on multiple-use public lands. It balances activities like grazing, mining, and recreation, while the U.S. Forest Service (FS) emphasizes sustainable forestry, wildlife habitats, and outdoor access. The National Park Service (NPS) preserves the nation’s iconic natural and cultural sites, prioritizing conservation and tourism. Meanwhile, the Fish and Wildlife Service (FWS) protects ecosystems critical for wildlife and biodiversity, and the Department of Defense (DOD) manages military installations vital to national security.

These agencies emerged during different periods in American history, often in response to westward expansion, resource management challenges, and conservation movements. Together, they illustrate the interplay of geography, history, and public policy in shaping the use of federal land across the United States.

### Department Mission Statements

**Bureau of Land Management**  
"To sustain the health, diversity, and productivity of public lands for the use and enjoyment of present and future generations."

**Forest Service**  
"To sustain the health, diversity, and productivity of the nation's forests and grasslands to meet the needs of present and future generations."

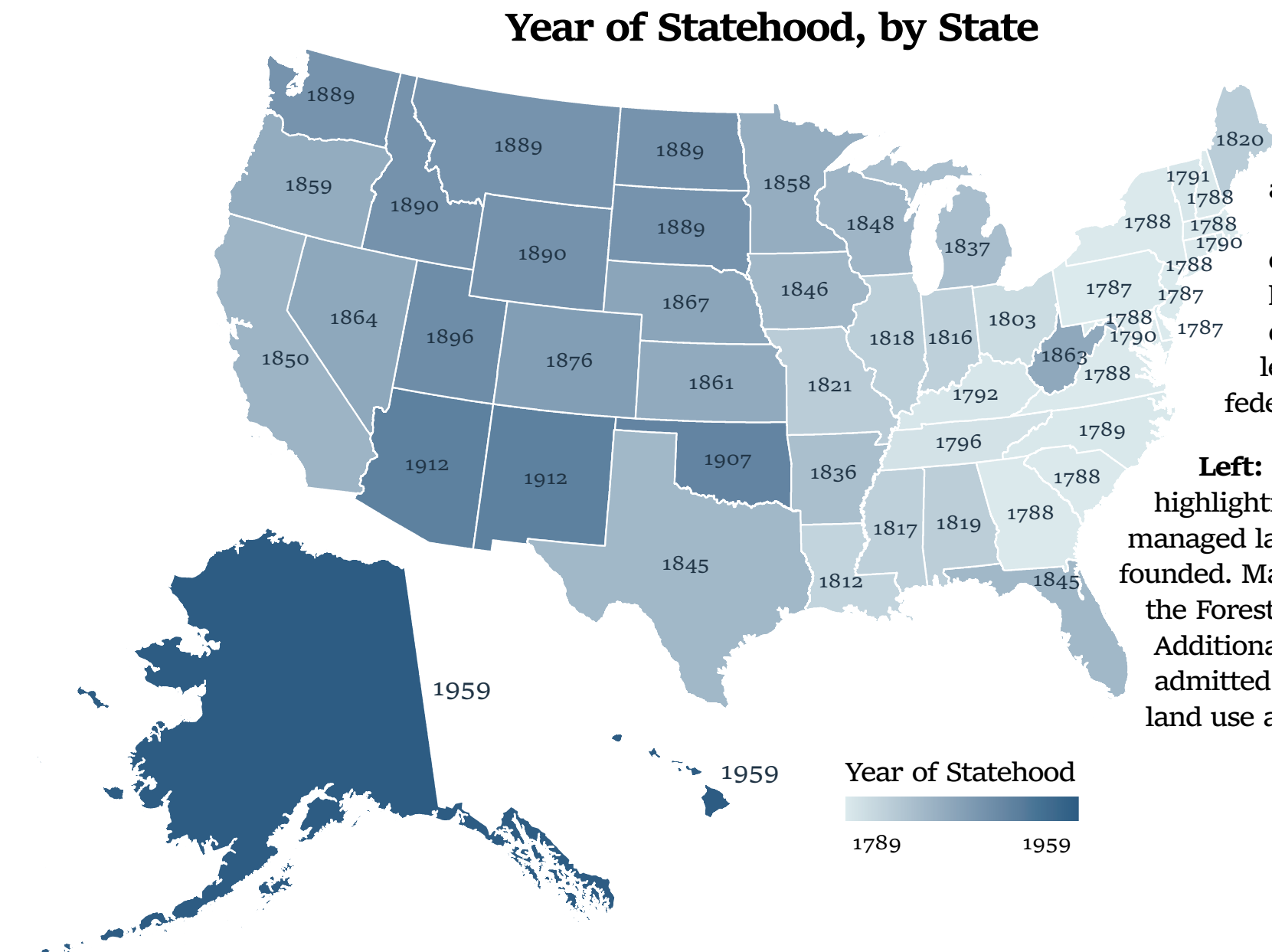
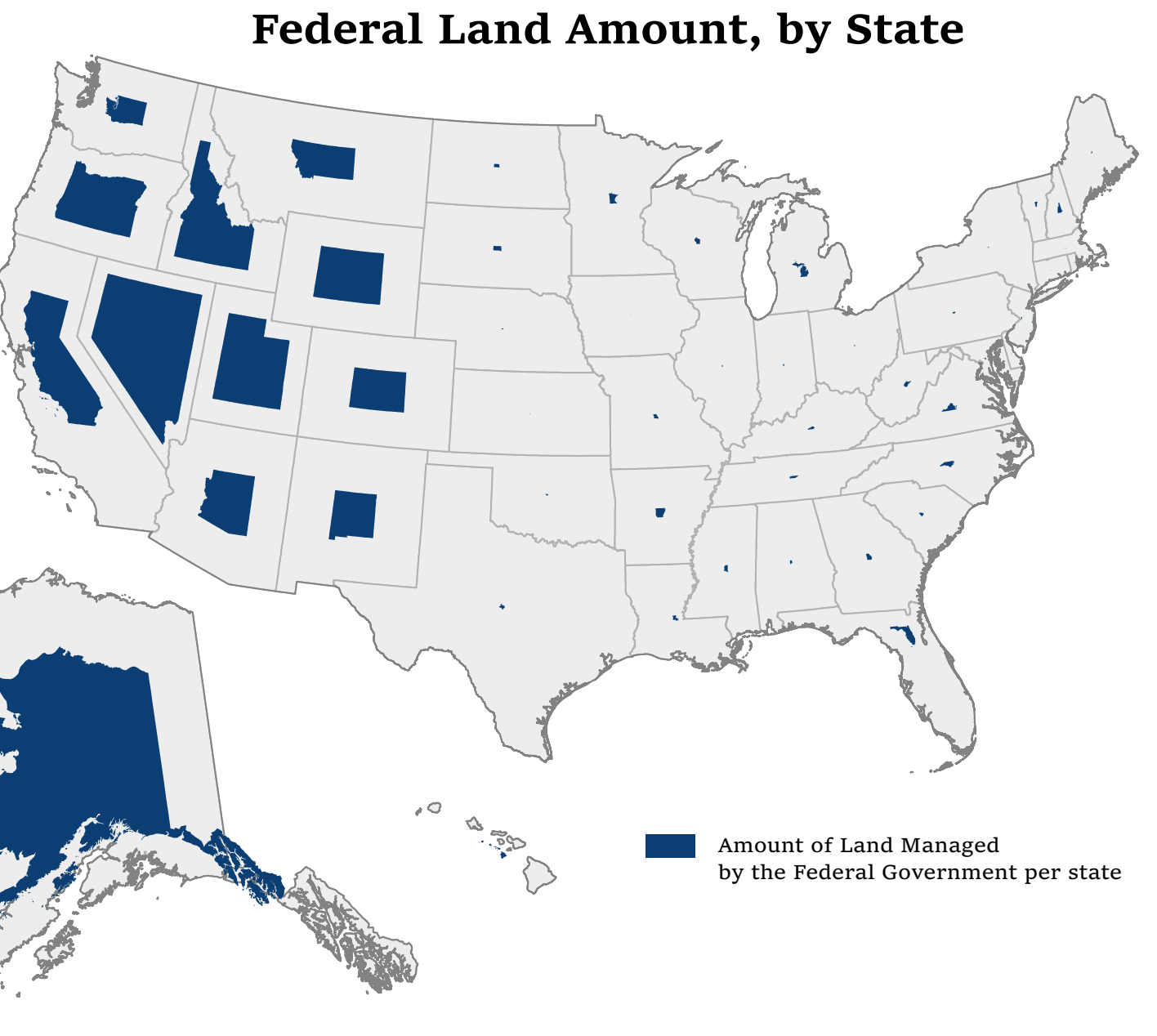
**Fish and Wildlife Service**  
"Working with others to conserve, protect, and enhance fish, wildlife, plants, and their habitats for the continuing benefit of the American people."

**National Park Service**  
To "preserve unimpaired the natural and cultural resources and values of the National Park System for the enjoyment, education, and inspiration of this and future generations."

**Department of Defense**  
"To provide the military forces needed to deter war and to protect the security of the United States."

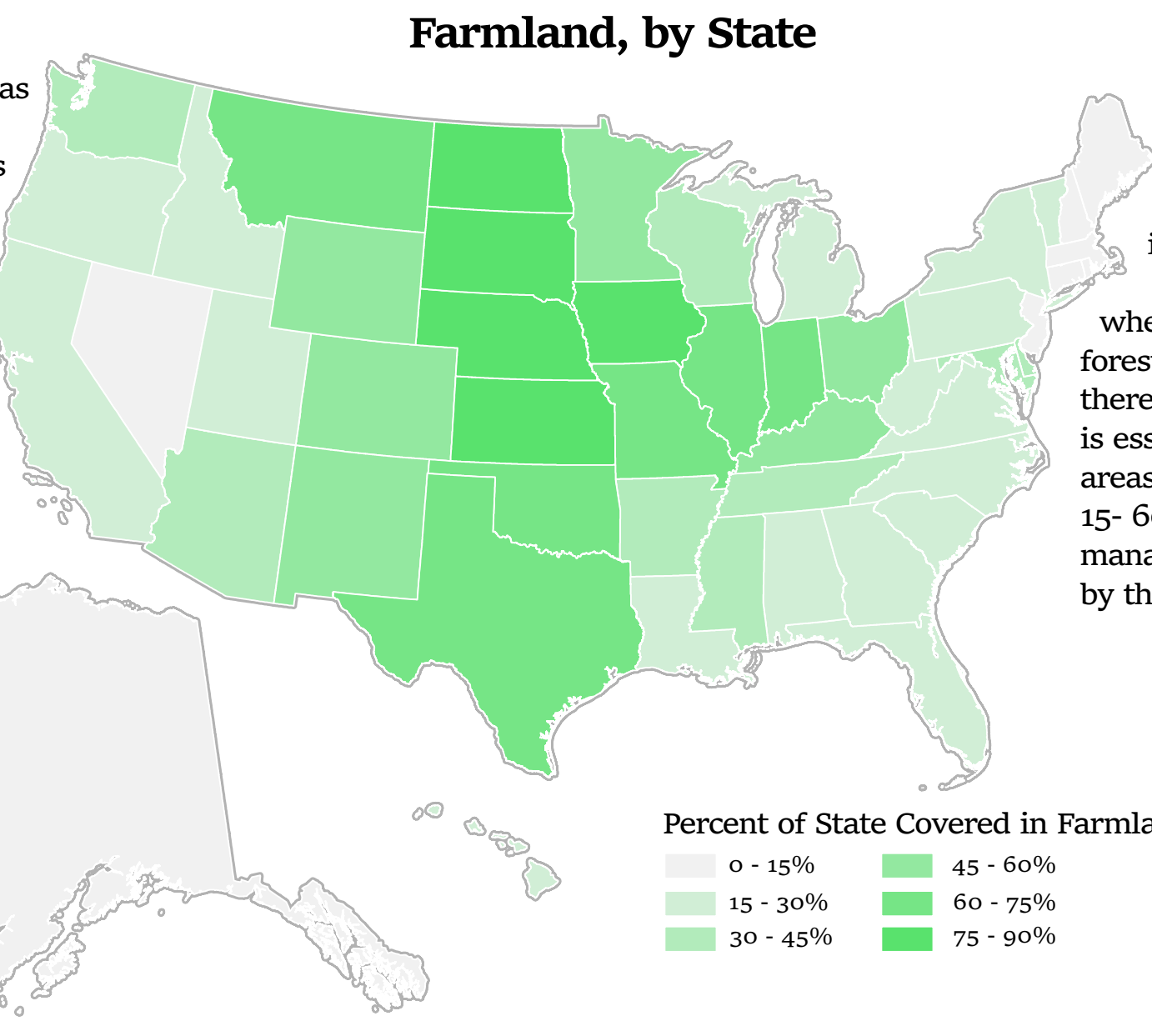
**Above:** The makeup of each state can tell us a lot about that state. States with a majority Forest Service land are mountainous and covered in forests: Washington, Idaho, Montana, Colorado. The presence of the Colorado Plateau and its deserts show up in states with lots of Bureau of Land Management land: Utah, Arizona, New Mexico. Even larger is the Great Basin desert that makes up much of Nevada, Utah, and California, which is primarily BLM land as well. Large areas of land used by the Department of Defense are also found in this desert, taking advantage of vast, uninhabited land. Most impressive is Alaska. Alaska is home to vast wildernesses of forests, mountains, tundra, and diverse wildlife. Much of it is BLM land, but the majority is protected by the Fish and Wildlife Service and the National Park Service. Much of the federal land in the east is FS land with the occasional National Park or Department of Defense base.

**Right:** This map shows clearly how much federal land there is in the west. The federal government manages the majority of the land in states like Nevada, Utah, and Idaho, and Alaska. The difference between the west and east halves on the country are stark. States like Iowa and Kansas have so little federal land that they are reduced to a speck.

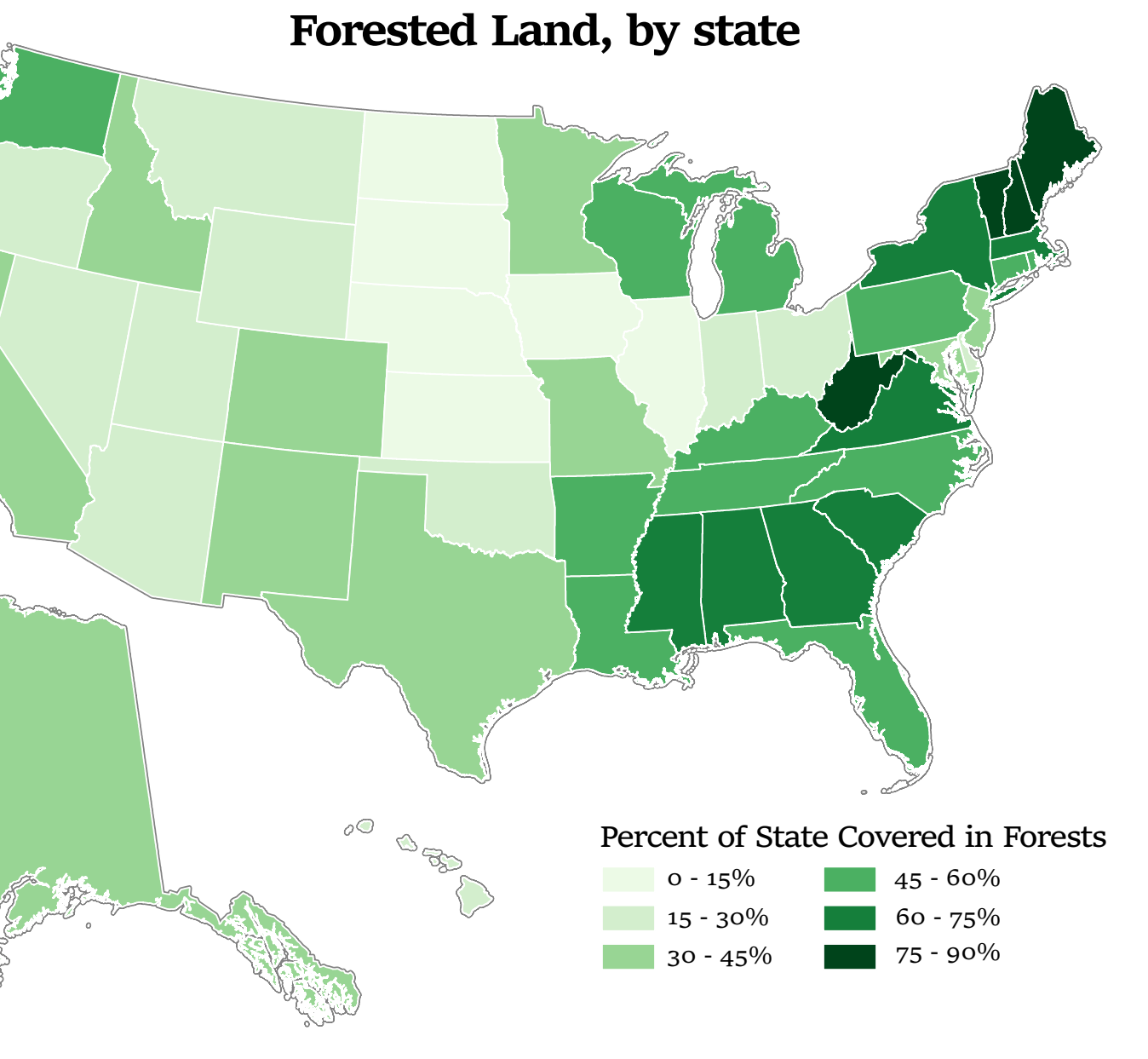


**Right:** The central US is characterized by a vast fertile area known as The Great Plains. In 1862, the federal government passed the Homestead Act, which granted land to settle and farm. Today, this area is dominated by expansive private farmland. This context helps us understand the lack of federal land in this area. The settlement of the remainder of the west went through a similar process, but high, mountainous areas and large deserts made the area less desirable to farmers and settlers. Thus one of the states with the least amount of farmland, Nevada, has the highest proportion of federal land, most of it managed by the Bureau of Land Management.

**Left:** This map shows the year each state was admitted to the Union, highlighting the correlation between statehood and the amount of federally managed land. Much of the eastern U.S. was settled before the country was founded. Many federal land management agencies, such as the BLM and the Forest Service, were established in the late 1800s and early 1900s. Additionally, states with less economically desirable land were often admitted later, as settlement and statehood were influenced by land use and availability.



**Right:** The US is home to any different bioregions, including diverse forests in New England, the South, the Mountain West, and the Pacific Northwest. This map shows their distribution across the US. So why is there so little FS land in these areas? This is partially because ownership of most of the land on the eastern half of the US was already set when the Forest Service was established. More importantly, forests in places like the Mountain West are less productive, and therefore more vulnerable to deforestation. The Forest Service is essential for healthy management and conservation in these areas. For this reason, the most FS land is found in states with 15- 60% forest cover. The state with the highest proportion of land managed by the Forest Service is Idaho. 38% of its land is managed by this federal department.



Sources: Congressional Research Service, Bureau of Land Management, National Park Service, U.S. Department of Defense, U.S. Fish & Wildlife Service, U.S. Forest Service, New York Times, Headwaters Economics, Farmland Information Center, World Population Review, Getty Images, Adobe Stock